

This is why I roll my eyes when people bring up the water usage of AI

Posted by u/Ironlixivium • 0 points • 25 comments

Just a quick disclaimer: I'm no AI techbro. I think it's neat, and I think it's a good tool for specific uses, like making a research paper to share on reddit because you don't have the time or motivation to make it yourself. I don't think it's coming for any jobs that we shouldn't be happy to have done automatically anyway.

I've seen and heard the claim many times that AI is a massive waste of water. I did enough research personally to figure out that the claim is massively overblown, but I was curious on exactly how overblown it is, so I simply asked Chat GPT's deep research model to figure that out for me. It did, and saved all the resources it used along the way to figure it out so that you don't have to trust it blindly (Something you should never do with an LLM; take them like someone's opinion, not fact). Okay, here it is:

[https://chatgpt.com/s/dr_6865846c0cdc8191a6bedb8210d71326]
(https://chatgpt.com/s/dr_6865846c0cdc8191a6bedb8210d71326)

It's actually quite short, but the TL;DR here is essentially that while it's true that AI does use a lot of water compared to any given person, it uses an absolutely microscopic amount on a grand scale. So little water that it's barely even worth talking about, and the only legitimate reason to jump all the way from our biggest water consuming industries to AI datacenters is if you personally don't like AI.

I've also seen the crux of this argument framed as whataboutism, which I can see, but in no way does that make it a less legitimate argument. Context matters, and on the topic of water waste, AI datacenters are not only not much of a concern, they are also already being made more efficient.

Comments

u/ComprehensiveCard663 • 1 points • 2025-10-13 09:43 UTC

I appreciate your research and opinion however all research is based on their lack of transparency. The actual numbers and information is kept under tight security. And that's not cuz it's good or minimal 500 000 to 3 million gallons per day one data center is devastating for everything that requires water to live. . and the actual numbers are higher .

u/ThinkExtension2328 • 1 points • 2025-07-03 10:01 UTC

Now ask it how much water social media uses, people forget ai at its core is a productive asset meanwhile tick-tock is just brain rot entertainment.

u/4gent0r • 1 points • 2025-07-03 01:39 UTC

I'd rather have AI than girls with makeup.

u/Ironlixivium • 1 points • 2025-07-03 02:17 UTC

That is quite the take.

Why that in specific? it looks like the makeup industry doesn't use much water once you exclude things like shampoo and rinse off hair products.

u/4gent0r • 1 points • 2025-07-03 06:32 UTC

Water Usage: The industry is estimated to use roughly 120 billion liters of water per year, with a large portion going into the production of plastic packaging [<https://www.lebube.com/post/beauty-industry-water-footprint>]
(<https://www.lebube.com/post/beauty-industry-water-footprint>)

u/Elliott-S9 • 2 points • 2025-07-02 23:04 UTC

Since AI is largely useless, it is a waste even if it's just a cup. Why do I have to turn off the faucet while I brush my teeth, but they can evaporate lakes for fun?

u/Ironlixivium • 1 points • 2025-07-03 00:46 UTC

I mean, I don't think that AI is useless, but I said that in my very first paragraph, so I doubt you care or are looking for any reason to change your opinion on that. That said, I think you could make the same arguments about the other ways we waste water:

Beef and almonds are largely useless, but we still waste trillions of gallons of water on them yearly. We could get the same or better nutrients from other less wasteful foods, but we don't. Assuming you can view beef as just as useless as AI, what makes those things ok while AI datacenters are not, especially considering that beef wastes more than 10x more water yearly?

u/Elliott-S9 • 1 points • 2025-07-03 01:39 UTC

Beef feeds people. AI makes slop that clogs the internet. Of course beef isn't the best option for food environmentally, but at least it does something. Almonds are very good for you while AI kills your critical thinking skills.

u/ComprehensiveCard663 • 1 points • 2025-10-13 09:36 UTC

Agreed. Ppl already don't think for themselves so ai makes those who do research information end up with four pages of search results that repeats the news media which is absolutely frightening when you think about it.

u/Such-Excitement3920 • 1 points • 2025-11-30 00:06 UTC

What are you saying

u/Ironlixivium • 1 points • 2025-07-03 02:12 UTC

I was trying to engage with you on your terms, but I see that you're only concerned with ragging on AI. Look, I don't think AI is all sunshine and rainbows, it's causing a lot of problems that we have no way to deal with. On the bright side, it can actually do a lot and it's quite useful if you learn to use it properly. (not just make slop and shit it onto the internet like you said)

Either way, the bottom line is that whether we like it or not, it's not going away and you need to deal with that. The US, China, and several other countries have decided its development is imperative for "defense", which means it's untouchable. You may as well try to stop a train with brute strength.

The best thing you can do for yourself is accept that. Maybe see what it can do for you, because you are very wrong about it being useless.

Also, I know the study you're talking about. it's a very tiny study group and the only thing they tried was getting people to prompt it to write essays. Of course if they have an AI write an essay then don't even read the essay they won't learn anything. That's not news.

Same with the "AI power users", who just outsource their thinking to AI. It can and should be used to help us think MORE. Not less.

u/Elliott-S9 • 1 points • 2025-07-03 11:50 UTC

What can it do? Research? No, thanks. It hallucinates far too much. Summarize things? No, thanks. I can read. Write an email? No, thanks. I'm a better writer. Vibe coding? I suppose, but you'd be far better off learning how to code.

Nothing is inevitable unless we want it to be. We could absolutely stop it, but we're choosing not to. But the governments aren't focused on things like chatbots anyway.

It will definitely destroy critical thinking skills. It's common sense. You would have to use it only in very specific ways to avoid this, but the vast majority of people are not informed enough to do so. The sad thing is that the people who will be most impacted are those who are already at risk. Cell phones alone are already doing tremendous damage. This will be the cherry on top.

u/Ironlixivium • 1 points • 2025-07-03 18:32 UTC

I actually agree with your last paragraph there. You have to use it mindfully and be well informed about it to not be hurt by it. It's already causing damage, and you're absolutely right that it will hit people at risk the hardest. It's tragic.

Hypothetically it's possible to stop this, yeah, but you're talking about globally unifying every country on this one issue, in a way

that the world has never been unified before. At a time when we're struggling to see eye to eye on even simple universally good ideas, like "war crimes are bad". Unifying on an actually controversial problem is out of the question.

Just look up how much taxpayer money is being spent on AI development right now. Not just in the US, but all over the world. We seriously cannot go back, and we cannot slow down.

Also, it sounds like the last time you interacted with an LLM was several years ago. They now rarely hallucinate, and are pretty decent at mundane tasks. Although, I would take issue with everything you asked about. It's all the garbage that the "power users" do.

It can research topics, you don't need to use the summary though. Just explain what you're looking for and it can scrub the internet for anything you might possibly need on the topic, then just read the sources. It's significantly faster than you and if you explain exactly what you want, it's way smarter than any search engine.

Everything else is kind of like that too. It's just a tool that can be used to make your life easier and free up time to do things that are actually worthwhile, like learning a new skill.

Speaking of which, AI has helped me learn python. No, vibe coding is disgusting. I mean actually learning, by just asking it questions and having it break things down into simple concepts for me I've been able to learn insanely quickly. In less than 3 months, I've already learned and repeatedly used most concepts in the language, as I'm closer than halfway to releasing my first professional app. While I have a day job. Honestly, I think everyone is missing out if they aren't using AI to help them learn, I've heard it's very good for learning new languages as well.

u/Elliott-S9 • 1 points • 2025-07-03 21:06 UTC

The new models actually hallucinate more than previous versions, and there is no known way to ever make it stop.

<https://www.nytimes.com/2025/05/05/technology/ai-hallucinations-chatgpt-google.html>

Much of what you're learning is incorrect. You have to fact check everything, so what's the point?

As far as new languages, code, etc. I could just as easily use my own research skills and YouTube.

The taxpayers money going to this is such a shame. We could easily end world hunger instead. What a catastrophe.

u/Deciheximal144 • 1 points • 2025-07-02 22:25 UTC

Water needs to be kept in closed-loop cooling, or a cosmic ray may split off the hydrogen, which will then escape from the planet. Cooling for compute is **environmental protection. 🤔**

u/Ironlixivium • 3 points • 2025-07-02 22:32 UTC

Lol, y'know, you have a point, we need to stop wasting water by drinking it and using it to make food. Only computer cooling is acceptable! Thank you for helping me see the light :)